Dancing Fish Granola Co.

US Label and Artwork Rulebook

Document	DF-QA-LBL-003
Version	3.2
Effective	1 September 2026
Owner	Regulatory and Quality
Approved by	Head of Regulatory Affairs

This rulebook explains how Dancing Fish reads the US labelling regulations for retail packs, and adds our own house rules on top. Artwork must pass every rule marked In force before it is released to print. Where our rule is stricter than the law, our rule applies.

Each rule has an ID, a status, the rule itself, and a short note on why it exists. A rule marked Proposed is guidance only and must not block a release.

Definitions

- **Front panel:** The principal display panel, the panel a shopper sees first on the shelf.
- **Mandatory text:** The statement of identity, net quantity, ingredient list, allergen statement, name and place of business, storage instructions and the Nutrition Facts panel.
- **Content sheet:** The approved product information for the SKU, kept by Regulatory. Artwork copy comes from it.
- **Release blocker:** A rule failure that stops the artwork going to print until it is fixed.
- **Needs review:** A rule that needs evidence the artwork cannot show, such as a certificate or a test report. A named person decides and the decision is recorded.

1. Approved information

DF-01 Approved content sheet

Status: In force

Rule: Artwork may only be signed off against a content sheet whose status is Approved. If the content sheet is still Draft or In Review, Regulatory must confirm the sheet before the artwork can be released.

Why: Copy checked against an unapproved sheet can be wrong in a way no check will catch.

DF-02 Copy matches the content sheet

Status: In force

Rule: All copy on the artwork must match the approved content sheet word for word, including ingredient order, ingredient percentages, allergen wording, claims and every nutrition value. Any difference is a release blocker until the artwork or the content sheet is corrected.

Why: The content sheet is the single source of truth. A silent difference means one of the two is wrong.

2. Front panel

DF-03 Statement of identity

Status: In force

Rule: The common name of the food must appear on the front panel and must be the largest text on that panel.

Why: Built on 21 CFR 101.3(a), which asks for the identity to be a principal feature of the front panel, and 101.3(d), which asks for bold type in a size reasonably related to the most prominent print. "Largest text" is our stricter house test.

DF-04 Net quantity

Status: In force

Rule: The net quantity must appear on the front panel, in the bottom 30% of the panel, in both metric and US units, written as "NET WT 480 g (16.9 oz)" with a space between each number and its unit.

Why: 21 CFR 101.7(a) and (f) require the net quantity on the principal display panel, in the bottom 30% of it. Metric as well as US units is required by the Fair Packaging and Labeling Act (15 U.S.C. 1453(a)(2)). The exact wording and the spacing are our house style.

3. Back and side panels

DF-05 Name and place of business

Status: In force

Rule: The back panel must state the manufacturer, packer or distributor, introduced by "Manufactured by", "Packed by" or "Distributed by", followed by the street address, city, state and ZIP code.

Why: 21 CFR 101.5(d) allows the street address to be left out when it is in a current city directory. We always print it, so customers and inspectors can reach us.

DF-06 Consumer care line

Status: In force

Rule: Every pack must carry a consumer care line on the back or a side panel: a US phone number or a website address.

Why: House rule. Complaints and allergy questions must reach us directly.

DF-07 Storage instructions

Status: In force

Rule: Storage instructions must appear on the back panel.

Why: Granola goes stale and soft when it is not stored dry. The instruction protects quality claims.

DF-08 Date and lot code area

Status: In force

Rule: When the copy sends the shopper to the base of the pack for the best-before date, the base panel must keep a clear, unprinted area of at least 40 mm by 15 mm for the date and lot code.

Why: The date and lot code are printed on the line. Artwork under the coder makes them unreadable.

DF-09 Nutrition Facts panel

Status: In force

Rule: The Nutrition Facts panel must sit on the back or a side panel, carry the title "Nutrition Facts", and end with the % Daily Value footnote.

Why: Our reading of 21 CFR 101.9 for a carton of this size.

DF-10 Daily values and calories

Status: In force

Rule: Every % Daily Value must be calculated from the declared amount per serving and the FDA daily value for that nutrient, and calories must agree with the declared fat, carbohydrate and protein.

Why: 21 CFR 101.9(c)(8)(iv) and (c)(9) set the daily values, and 101.9(d)(7)(ii) sets the percent calculation, rounded to the nearest whole percent. A wrong percentage is a labelling error even when the gram amount is right.

DF-11 US English and US formats

Status: In force

Rule: US packs use US English and US formats only: no EU nutrition tables, no kilojoule energy values, no Reference Intake icons and no UK spellings such as "Fibre" or "Flavouring".

Why: Artwork adapted from a European pack often keeps European elements that confuse US shoppers.

4. Ingredients and allergens

DF-12 Allergen statement

Status: In force

Rule: Major food allergens that are ingredients must be declared in a "Contains:" statement placed directly after the ingredient list. "May contain" wording is only for cross-contact and must never name an allergen that is an ingredient in the recipe.

Why: Section 403(w) of the FD&C Act (21 U.S.C. 343(w), from the Food Allergen Labeling and Consumer Protection Act), with sesame added by the FASTER Act from 1 January 2023. The law lets a pack name the allergen in the ingredient list or in a "Contains" statement; requiring "Contains" is our house rule. A "may contain" warning for a real ingredient understates the risk.

5. Claims

DF-13 Sugar claims

Status: In force

Rule: "No Added Sugar", "No Sugar Added" and "Without Added Sugar" may only be used when no sugar or sugar-containing ingredient is added. Honey, coconut sugar, cane sugar, syrups and fruit juice concentrates all count as added sugars.

Why: Our reading of 21 CFR 101.60(c)(2), which bars added sugars and ingredients that contain them, such as concentrated fruit juice.

DF-14 Vegan and vegetarian

Status: In force

Rule: "Vegan" may only be used when the recipe contains no animal-derived ingredient and the Certified Vegan certificate is on file. Honey is animal-derived. "Vegetarian" and "vegan" must never be used as if they mean the same thing.

Why: No US regulation defines vegan, so we follow the Certified Vegan standard (vegan.org).

DF-15 Organic claims

Status: In force

Rule: "Organic", "certified organic" and the USDA Organic seal may only be used when the current organic certificate for this recipe is on file with Regulatory.

Why: USDA National Organic Program, 7 CFR Part 205 (labelling in 205.300 and 205.301). The certificate is evidence the artwork cannot show.

DF-16 GMO wording

Status: In force

Rule: The words "GMO free" are not used on any pack. The approved wording is "Non-GMO Project Verified", and only when the verification is on file.

Why: FDA's voluntary labeling guidance (November 2015, revised March 2019, non-binding) recommends against "free" wording for genetic engineering because it is hard to substantiate. Version 3.1 replaced it with verified wording.

DF-17 Claims built on "high"

Status: In force

Rule: Claims built on the word "high", such as "High Fiber", "High Protein" or "High-Grain", must be approved by Regulatory before use.

Why: "High" is a defined nutrient content claim: 21 CFR 101.54(b) allows it only when the food has 20 percent or more of the daily value per reference amount customarily consumed. With other words it can still read as one, so a person decides.

6. Legibility and the artwork file

DF-18 Minimum text size

Status: In force

Rule: Mandatory text must be set at 6 pt or larger.

Why: House rule for readability. It does not replace the 1/16 inch minimum letter height in 21 CFR 101.2(c) (measured on the lowercase "o", see 101.7(h)(2)), which Regulatory checks on the printed proof.

DF-19 No hidden content

Status: In force

Rule: Release files must not contain hidden text: no text covered by other artwork, on switched-off layers or outside the trim. Hidden copy must be deleted from the file, not covered.

Why: Hidden copy can print if a layer or a fill moves at the printer. Added after the 2026 reprint of a carton that printed an old nutrition table.

DF-20 Recycling label

Status: In force

Rule: The How2Recycle label must appear on the back panel or the base panel.

Why: Retailer requirement for paperboard cartons.

7. Proposed rules

DF-21 Front-of-pack nutrition box

Status: Proposed

Rule: When FDA finalises its January 2025 proposed rule on front-of-package nutrition information, the front panel will carry a Nutrition Info box showing saturated fat, sodium and added sugars as Low, Med or High.

Why: Planning only (FDA proposed rule published 16 January 2025, Federal Register document 2025-00778; not yet final when checked). Do not apply until Regulatory issues version 4 of this rulebook.

Change log

Version	Date	Change
3.2	1 September 2026	Added DF-19 (no hidden content) and DF-08 (date and lot code area).
3.1	3 March 2026	Replaced "GMO free" with verified wording (DF-16). Added DF-06 (consumer care line).
3.0	12 January 2026	First version for the US range.